

DAMNED

Anti-India frenzy intensifies as Kashmir erupts in the wake of the Amarnath land dispute. The deepening communal polarisation is further aggravated by the alliance of the so-called national politicians from the Valley and the separatists.



AP DAN YASIN

including a leading Hurriyat leader Sheikh Abdul Aziz. This happened during the Muzaffarabad march on the call of separatist groups. Aziz's death provoked violence and massive angry protests in the Valley with the Muslim-dominated Kishtwar district in Jammu brazenly defying curfew. In two days of violence, at least 17 persons were killed in Kashmir in the firing by security forces to enforce curfew, while two died during the first major communal clash in Jammu.

In an ominous pointer to a growing separatist mood, protesters freed top Hurriyat leaders Mirwaiz Umar Farooq and hardliner Syed Ali Shah Geelani from house arrest in Srinagar, forcing the police to beat a hasty retreat. For the first time since 1995, the entire Valley has been placed under curfew. While Patil had another round of all-party meeting in Delhi to take stock of the deteriorating situation in Kashmir, his surprise announcement that the Centre had no objection to Kashmiri fruit growers exporting their produce to Pakistan via Muzaffarabad has puzzled political observers in the troubled state as it



"It is not just a land transfer issue. It's a question of our faith, honour and patriotism."

LEELA KARAN SHARMA, SAMITI CONVENER

flew in the face of the state authorities' claim that the Jammu-Srinagar highway was open and there was no economic blockade due to unrest in Jammu. The home minister's statement can only embolden the separatists to push for their new-found exhortation to Kashmiris to breach the LOC, symbolising their pro-Pakistan leanings.

It was a counterblast orchestrated by the Hurriyat factions which have now made a common cause with each other in their tenacious opposition to the land transfer to the Shri Amarnath Yatra Shrine Board.